

Nothing Ear (2)

An incremental update in a competitive space

The Nothing Ear (2) are competing with the likes of the OnePlus Buds Pro 2, Jabra Elite Active 4, and the Oppo Enco X2. All three earbuds hold their ground well, so Nothing Ear (2) had an uphill battle to fight. Spoiler alert – it almost came out as the victor. Almost is the keyword. Curious why? Read the review and find out –

BUILD, DESIGN, AND FIT

Nothing's products stand out and are a treat to look at. The design overall has retained the quintessential Ear (1) look. However, upon closer inspection, you start noticing the subtle differences. The plastic still has that glossy finish and quality, which in our few days of use, caught a lot of scratches and scuffs. The hinge is smaller yet stronger and it is also metallic, which is always appreciated. The earbuds also follow the same theme. They have received small changes, apart from one, which are the controls. Now, instead of the touch-sensitive gesture-based controls, Nothing has added pinch controls on the stem. I honestly love the way that they work and feel during regular use.

FEATURES

The Nothing Ear (2) is not the most feature-rich pair of earbuds that is out there in the market around the ₹10K mark. We have the Oppo Enco X2, which is laden with features, almost all of which are well-implemented. Nothing against the Nothing Ear (2), though. With the Ear (2), we also get audio personalisation. After the personalisation, the sound signature did not change drastically. It was just that the positioning and overall staging of whatever audio was being pushed by the drivers became more precise. A new feature that affects the performance is the support for 24-bit Hi-Res audio and the LHDC codec. The Nothing X app is something that other brands can take inspiration from.



There are a ton of features which are well-implemented. They come with an Ingress Protection (IP) rating of IP55. Don't jump into the pool with these on, though.

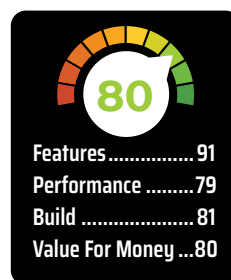
PERFORMANCE

Nothing Ear (2) bring a ton of incremental upgrades here. The bass has been amplified. However, it is balanced out by the highs, which have also been boosted. The overall sound signature is U-shaped which is the go-to for most consumer brands, and in daily usage, also sounds well-rounded if done well, which, as you will see, is not really the case with the Nothing Ear (2). The boost in the higher frequencies introduces sibilance, which means that there's always high-pitched S and T sounds present in the audio. And that is not pleasant to listen to. Most of the competing earbuds have a much more balanced sound-signature, which, once you experience for yourself, you will appreciate. As for the ANC, they come pretty close to the Oppo Enco X2, which is our pick in this price range. In indoor conditions, these earbuds hold their own. However, as soon as you step out in a noisy environment, you feel the lacklustre ANC performance on these earbuds. The microphone performance of

these earbuds is something that I loved. The extended stem and the microphones baked in these earbuds work great. Talking about gaming, the low latency mode brought down the latency by a considerable amount.

BATTERY LIFE

These earbuds clocked in about four and a half hours, compared to the three and a half hours of the Nothing Ear (1). With ANC turned off, you can expect about an hour to be added to the battery life of the earbuds. With the case, you get about four more rounds of charging, bringing the total battery life up to 18.8 hours with ANC turned on and 22 hours with ANC turned off. If you are out of juice, you can use the included USB Type-C cable or plonk these on to a wireless charging pad. There's fast charging as well



VERDICT

The Nothing Ear (2) is a great pair of earbuds for regular folk if they are dedicated fans of the brand. These earbuds go into tricky waters when you start comparing them to the offerings from

OnePlus, Oppo, and Jabra. In terms of sound quality, all three earbuds are more balanced-sounding than the Nothing. We are talking about out of box experience here. You can tune the audio and match the levels of the competition. But, in terms of design, they are hands down some of the best earbuds you can get. They are, what they say, conversation starters. Nothing (literally, not the brand) matches up to these earbuds.

–Sativik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Driver: 11.6 mm dynamic | Diaphragm: Graphene + PU (Polyurethane) | Bluetooth codec: AAC, SBC, LHDC | Tuning: Nothing | Noise cancellation: Up to 40 dB | Battery: Rechargeable Li-ion battery | Capacity: 33 mAh (buds) / 485 mAh (case) | Bluetooth version: BT 5.3 | Compatibility: Android 5.1 and above, iOS 11 and above

CONTACT

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